



BUILD GUIDE A · GENERAL BUSINESS DATA

The weekly report

Scattered sources in. One clean recurring document out. A fictional 14-person Philadelphia design and web studio. No financial vocabulary anywhere. Everything you need is in this one document.

01 / DIAGNOSIS

Is this your problem?

Scattered sources go in. One clean recurring document comes out. Every week, every month, forever, and you rebuild it from scratch every single time.

- ☐ There is a document you write on a rhythm, and its structure barely changes.
- ☐ Most of the work is gathering and formatting, not thinking.
- ☐ You pull from more than one place: a spreadsheet, a portal, an inbox, a few people's updates.
- ☐ If you handed someone your raw inputs and nothing else, they could produce a worse version of it without asking you a single question.

Three or more ticks and you are in the right guide. Typical shapes: the weekly cash and runway view, the Monday investment committee brief, the client status update, the pipeline summary, the month-end commentary, the board pre-read.

02 / START HERE

Two boxes. That is the whole thing.

Every tool has two places to type. Getting them the wrong way round is the most common mistake in the room, and it produces output that looks almost right and is useless tomorrow.

TOP BOX · PASTE ONCE, LEAVE IT THERE

The instruction

Google AI Studio: the panel on the right labelled *System instructions*. **Claude:** make a Project, then *Project instructions*. **ChatGPT:** make a Project, or a Custom GPT, then *Instructions*.

This is the thing you are building tonight. It stays put. You never retype it.



BOTTOM BOX · PASTE FRESH EVERY RUN

The data

The normal chat box at the bottom of the screen, where you would usually type a question.

This changes every time. Tonight it is workshop data. On Monday it is your real work.

Three steps. Everything you need is in this document.

01

Open your tool

aistudio.google.com is fastest if you have a Google account. claude.ai or chatgpt.com work identically.

02

Copy Section 03 of this guide into the TOP box

All of it, first line to last. Do not edit it. Do not fill anything in. It is already complete and ready to run.

03

Copy Section 04 of this guide into the BOTTOM box, then press run

Section 04 is two weekly operating snapshots for Fairmount Studio. Run week 1 first, then start a brand new chat and run week 2.

IF THE OUTPUT LOOKS STRANGE, CHECK WHICH BOX YOU USED

Instruction in the bottom box means you asked a one-off question and built nothing reusable. Data in the top box means every future run will be contaminated with tonight's numbers. Both produce something that reads fine and is wrong. This one mistake accounts for most of the confusion in any workshop like this, and it takes ten seconds to check.

YOU DO NOT NEED TO OPEN ANYTHING ELSE

The instruction, the data and the answer key are all in this document. Run it as written first, even though it is about a firm that is not yours. Seeing the pattern work end to end takes four minutes and makes every decision after it obvious. Section 07 turns it into your own.

Copy this into the top box

Complete and ready to run. No brackets to fill, nothing to decide. Copy every line.

You write the Monday Morning Brief for the Fairmount Studio partners. They read it to decide what needs attention this week. They spend ninety seconds on it.

INPUT

I will paste a weekly operating snapshot (projects, hours, cash, invoices, enquiries) and a set of short notes from around the studio. It will be unformatted and may be incomplete.

OUTPUT

Produce the brief with exactly these sections, in this order, using these exact headings:

1. **Headline** - one sentence, maximum 20 words, about ONE thing.
If several things changed, pick the one that most needs a decision. Never join two items with "and" or "as".
2. **Numbers that moved** - maximum five bullets. Each one: metric, prior value, current value, change, one clause on why.
3. **Projects to watch** - maximum three bullets. One line per project where something in the notes changes our view. Name the project.
4. **Needs a decision** - maximum three bullets. Each one names the decision and the person who owns it.
5. **Check these** - anything that looks wrong, contradicts itself, or is missing.

RULES

- Under 250 words total.
- Plain and factual. No adjectives of quality. Do not write "strong", "solid", "healthy", or "disappointing". Report what changed.
- Copy every figure in the same units and format the input used. Never convert between dollars, thousands and millions.
\$121,450 stays \$121,450. 412 hours stays 412 hours.
- Dates as 31 Mar 2026. Percentages to one decimal place.
- Every figure must carry its as-of date if the input gives one.
- Never include a figure that is not in the input.
- No preamble. Start at section 1.

REFUSALS

- If a figure is missing, write "not provided" and list it under Check these. Never estimate, never carry forward last week.
- If two inputs give different values for the same thing, report both with their sources and flag it. Do not pick one.
- If two figures differ only because they are as of different dates, say so explicitly rather than treating it as a discrepancy.
- Never supply an as-of date that is not in the input. If the input does not give one, write "date not stated". Do not use today's date and do not infer one from the reporting period.

Section 08 has the same instruction with the specifics stripped out and brackets in their place, for when you point this at your own work.

04 / THE DATA

Copy this into the bottom box

Two consecutive weeks from Fairmount Studio. Run week 1 first. Then start a brand new chat, paste the instruction again, and run week 2, so nothing carries over.

RUN ONE · WEEK ENDING 24 JULY 2026

Active projects: 9
Projects flagged at risk: 1
Hours logged: 412
Billable utilisation: 71%
Invoices outstanding: \$84,300
Cash at bank: \$121,450
New enquiries: 4
Proposals out: 3
Headcount: 14
Days to quarter end: 68

Notes:

- Bellwether Coffee rebrand: on track, phase 2 kickoff 28 July.
- Ludlow Bicycle site build: client has not returned content, second chase sent.
- Kensington Health: proposal sent 22 July, no response yet.
- Hiring: two offers out, both accepted, start dates 27 July.
- Ops: nothing outstanding.

RUN TWO · WEEK ENDING 31 JULY 2026 · NEW CHAT

Active projects: 10
Projects flagged at risk: 3
Hours logged: 388
Invoices outstanding: \$96,700
Cash at bank: \$103,900
New enquiries: 2
Proposals out: 5
Days to quarter end: 61

Notes:

- Headcount was 14 as of 1 July and is 16 as of 28 July after the two hires started. Both figures are correct, they are different dates.
- The team logged 438 hours this week across all projects.
- Billable utilisation has not been calculated this week. The ops lead is out until 4 August.
- Ludlow Bicycle site build: client content still outstanding, now flagged at risk.
- Bellwether Coffee: phase 2 started on schedule.
- Kensington Health: proposal declined on price. Worth a debrief.

Did it actually work?

Two runs, not one. Run two contains a missing field and a contradictory figure, both deliberate. This is where you find out whether you built a tool or a demo.

01

Shape

Put both outputs side by side. Could you paste them into the same template without editing a single heading? If not, your OUTPUT section is too loose. Name the sections harder.

02

The hole

Billable utilisation is missing from run two. Pass: it reads "not provided" and appears under Check these. Fail: a number appears. If it produced a number here it will produce one on your real data, and everything this tool makes is now suspect.

03

The contradiction

Run two gives **388 hours and 438 hours** for the same thing. Pass: both reported and flagged. Fail: it silently picked one. Silently picking is the failure that costs money, because it looks exactly like success.

04

The one that is not a contradiction

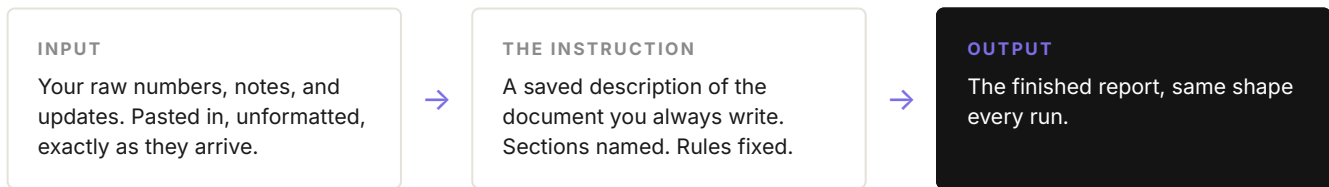
Run two also gives **headcount of 14 and 16**. Those are both correct, because they are as of different dates. Pass: both reported with their dates, not flagged. Fail: flagged as a conflict, or one date dropped. This is the hardest of the four and the one most likely to miss.

IF IT INVENTED THE MISSING NUMBER

Move the REFUSALS block to the *top* of your instruction, above OUTPUT, and add:

Before writing anything, list any input field that is empty or absent. Making the check happen first rather than last fixes this almost every time.

What you are building



The instruction is the asset. You write it once tonight and then feed it new inputs forever. The reason this works is that your report already has a fixed structure in your head. You are just writing that structure down for the first time.

Swap in your own work

You have a working version. Now point it at your own work. About twenty minutes, and the result is the thing you actually use on Monday.

MINUTES 0 TO 3

01

Work on a copy, not the version that works

Open a new prompt and paste the same instruction into its top box. Edit the copy. Keeping a known-good version intact means that when an edit breaks something, you can see exactly what changed instead of guessing.

MINUTES 3 TO 6

02

Name the reader and the decision

Before you write anything else, answer this out loud: who reads this document, and what do they do differently after reading it? "The four partners, and they decide what gets escalated this week." That single sentence controls the tone, the length, and what gets cut. Skip it and you will produce a report that is technically complete and useless.

MINUTES 6 TO 12

03

Write the sections out, by name

Open the actual report you wrote last week. List its sections. Not "an overview and then the details." The literal headings. If your current report does not have consistent headings, this is the moment you decide what they are, and that alone is worth the hour.

Three to five sections. Any more and nobody reads it. Every section gets a one-line description of what belongs in it.

MINUTES 12 TO 16

04

Paste the blank scaffold in Section 06 and fill the brackets

Do not write it from scratch. Replace every bracket. If a bracket does not apply, delete the line rather than leaving it vague.

MINUTES 16 TO 21

05

Run it on last week's real inputs

Synthetic or public inputs only tonight. Paste the raw material into the chat, not into the system instruction. Run it.

MINUTES 21 TO 25

06

Run it again on a different week and compare shapes

This is the step that proves it. Section 07 tells you exactly what to look at.

The version with the brackets

You write my [NAME OF REPORT] for [WHO READS IT].
They read it to decide [WHAT DECISION THEY MAKE]. They have
[HOW LONG THEY ACTUALLY SPEND ON IT].

INPUT

I will paste [describe exactly what you paste: raw numbers, exported rows, notes from people, a table with these columns]. It will be unformatted and it may be incomplete.

OUTPUT

Produce the report with exactly these sections, in this order, using these exact headings:

1. [Section name] - [what goes in it, and how long]
2. [Section name] - [what goes in it, and how long]
3. [Section name] - [what goes in it, and how long]
4. Check these - anything in the input that looks wrong, contradicts itself, or is missing.

RULES

- Under [N] words total.
- Tone: [plain and factual / brief and direct]. No adjectives of quality. Do not characterise performance as strong, solid, or disappointing. Report what changed.
- Currency as [\$X.XM]. Dates as [31 Mar 2026]. Percentages to [one] decimal place.
- Never include a figure that is not in the input. Do not calculate anything I did not ask for.
- No preamble, no sign-off, no "here is your report". Start at section 1.

REFUSALS

- If a figure is missing, write "not provided" in place and list it under Check these. Never estimate, never carry forward last period's number.
- If two inputs give different values for the same thing, report both with their sources and flag it. Do not pick one.
- If the input is for a different period than I said, say so and stop.

THE TWO LINES PEOPLE DELETE, AND SHOULD NOT

"Check these" as a permanent section, and **"never estimate, never carry forward last period's number."** Together they turn the model from something that produces a confident document into something that produces a document plus a list of what to verify. The second one is a report you can actually put your name on.

When it goes wrong

WHAT YOU SEE

WHAT TO CHANGE

Output structure drifts between runs.

Your OUTPUT section describes topics, not headings. Write the literal heading text and add "using these exact headings".

It writes "strong quarter" and other commentary you did not ask for.

Ban the specific words. Models comply with named prohibitions far better than with general tone guidance.

It is too long no matter what you say.

Put a cap on each section, not just the total. "Maximum five bullets" beats "under 250 words".

A figure comes back in absurd units. \$82 billion appears as \$82,000.0M, or a bank balance appears as \$0.49M.

Your format rule is being applied to every number regardless of scale. Replace it with "copy every figure in the same units the input used, never convert between thousands, millions and billions", plus one literal example of each. This is the most common own goal in this pattern.

It reformats your numbers differently each time.

Give one literal example of each format in the RULES block. Not a description, an example.

Good on short inputs, degrades on long ones.

You are hitting the practical limit of one pass. Split into two steps: first extract the figures into a table, then write the brief from the table. This is rung 3 of the ladder (Foundations, Section 07).

It answers questions instead of writing the report.

Add: "Never ask me a question. If information is missing, note it under Check these and continue."

10 / FURTHER

Three rungs up, after tonight

01

Give it reach (connectors)

Instead of pasting the snapshot, connect the Drive folder or sheet the numbers already live in. In Claude or ChatGPT, turn on the Google Drive connector and change your INPUT line to: "read the current week's tab in the sheet named X." You have removed the copy and paste step, which is usually a third of the work.

02

Put it on a timer (scheduled agent)

Once it has run cleanly by hand for two weeks, schedule it for Monday 6am with the output landing in a doc or a draft email *to yourself*. Never to the distribution list. The agent drafts, you read, you send. See Foundations, Section 06.

03

Chain it (agentic workflow)

Step one pulls and normalises the numbers. Step two checks them against last week and flags anything that moved more than a threshold. Step three writes the brief from the checked table. Three inspectable steps beat one opaque one, and the quality difference on long inputs is not subtle. Build this in n8n or Make when it matters enough to own.

MONDAY

Do not roll this out. Use it once, yourself, on the real thing, with the output in front of you and last week's manual version beside it. Note where it was wrong. Fix those two lines in the instruction. That is week one.

Tell one colleague in week two. Tell the firm in month two, if it survived.

Everything you need is in this document. The instruction (Section 03), the data (Section 04), the answer key (Section 05), and the blank version for your own work (Section 08). You do not need to open another file.

Fairmount Studio is not a real firm. All client names, staff, invoices, memos and inbox items are invented for this workshop. No real person appears anywhere in this data.

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